

The Daintree Rain Forest

Australia's largest tropical rain forest, one of the oldest and most biodiverse in the world, with a striking array of plants and animals



Covering 460 square miles (1,200 square km) in northeastern Queensland, the Daintree is the largest tropical rain forest in Australia and one of the oldest on Earth. Estimates of its age vary from 135 to 180 million years. Part of the Wet Tropics World Heritage Site, it contains the closest living relatives of prehistoric rain forest plant species that covered the continent millions of years ago. These include the ribbonwood tree, also known as the idiot fruit or green dinosaur. A primitive



evergreen dating back 120–170 million years, it was believed to be extinct until 1971. Half of Australia's bird species, a third of its frogs and mammals, a quarter of its reptiles, and more than 12,000 insect species have been catalogued in the Daintree, many of them living nowhere else.

◀ RAIN FOREST WARDEN

The endangered flightless southern cassowary is among the Daintree's residents and is an important disperser of tree seeds.



The Daintree contains the **greatest concentration of birds** in all of **Australia**

Eastern Australian Temperate Forest

Home to more than one-fifth of Australia's eucalyptus trees, the oils of which give nearby mountains their blue haze



▽ TOWERING TREES

Near the Great Dividing Range, which forms the ecoregion's inland boundary, eucalyptus trees rise above smaller trees such as acacia.

Stretching from the New South Wales central coast into southeast Queensland, the Eastern Australian Temperate Forest ecoregion covers 85,750 square miles (222,100 square km). Varying altitudes and microclimates support a wide range of vegetation, but the eucalyptus is the region's dominant plant—more than 100 species of eucalyptus, also known as gum trees, grow here. Airborne oil droplets from eucalyptus leaves are believed to refract blue light, lending the area's Blue Mountains their colorful haze. More importantly, these gum tree forests are home to many endangered plant and animal species, including the iconic koala.



▷ HOLDING TIGHT

The koala initially carries its young, or joey, in a pouch. Eventually, the joey clings to its mother's back as she feeds on eucalyptus leaves.

